negotiations on the border, the letter argued for greater attention to border security.

With Patel's death, it was left to Bajpai and Foreign Secretary K.P.S. Menon to get Nehru to engage more fully with the threat they saw from China. They urged that a Tibet accord should be linked to Beijing's settlement of the borders with Delhi. However, Panikkar disregarded their instructions.[4] He explained his view later to Bajpai. If India raised the issue, China would either accept the McMahon Line or refuse to accept the line and ask for negotiations. Since the former was improbable, it would choose negotiations, which India would find hard to avoid since Delhi would have been responsible for initiating discussions on the border in the first place. If on the other hand China was left to raise the border issue, India could simply assert, as Nehru already had publicly, that India's boundaries were fixed and there was nothing to discuss. Behind this view, according to Srinath Raghavan, was Panikkar's larger point that instead of becoming embroiled in negotiations, it should turn its attention to shoring up its administration in the borderlands.[5]

Nehru was initially inclined to go with Panikkar's view, but when he saw a Chinese reference to the borders as being a 'scar' of imperialism, he felt it was 'better to be absolutely straight and frank'.[6] Bajpai, retired from the foreign service and now Governor of Bombay State, once again disagreed with Panikkar's soft-pedalling. Writing to his successor in Delhi, he presciently warned that China 'may seek to heal or erase this scar on the basis of frontier rectifications that may not be to our liking'.[7] In the meantime, Panikkar had finished his term in Beijing. Upon his return to Delhi, he persuaded a wavering Nehru that it was not the right time to talk to China about the border. In the end Nehru, after tilting one way and then another, seems to have agreed with Panikkar that India was not ready to negotiate, given its uneven control and administrative reach in the borderlands. He therefore ordered India's diplomats to avoid discussion on the border issue in the negotiations over Tibet.[8]

Clearly, in private, the Indian view was that China would challenge the border as it was then defined. Delhi would have to deal with the matter –